Bridge 1 and Charlie Company's position at the Drokung Samba Bridge. The Chinese engaged elements of No. 5 Platoon with small arms fire in the morning and one of the soldiers had been killed. When Balbir Singh started to extricate his platoon, they had to traverse across the Khenzemane grazing grounds that were covered by a Chinese MMG on the cliffs above. An attached artillery officer, Lieutenant A. S. Balasubramaniam from 51 Mountain Regiment, who had been sent as a forward observer, was killed while trying to negotiate this patch. A nursing orderly who immediately went to his aid was also gunned down.

As the main body of 4 Grenadiers began to withdraw towards Hathung-la, the same MMG post that had killed Balasubramaniam had a section of the track in range. To avoid this patch, Harihar Singh asked his Intelligence officer, Second Lieutenant R. I. S. Kahlon, who was in the lead, to skirt the area. The troops were to move through the vegetation keeping the Hathung-la track to their left, and rejoin it after half a kilometre. Second Lieutenant Kartar Singh of Bravo Company with No. 4 Platoon was to be the rearguard, and was to follow half an hour after the battalion's departure. As the troops started to move through the foliage, Harihar Singh changed the order and told the troops to abandon the Hathung-la track altogether and head straight up the slope like Mishra had a few hours earlier.

Lieutenant Kartar Singh, oblivious of the last-minute change in plan, fell back by rejoining the Hathung-la track. He and his platoon made it to Serkhim without any further incident, which only went to prove that had 9 Punjab and 4 Grenadiers followed the Hathung-la track as ordered, they would have been able to get across the pass in good order. Why Mishra and Harihar Singh acted in this manner is beyond comprehension; had they fallen back as instructed, the remaining two battalions of 7 Brigade might have managed to deploy beyond Hathung-la and fight it out.

The Chinese finally attacked Hathung-la in the early hours of 21 October. Jemadar Gian Singh and the thirty-two-man No. 10 Platoon at Hathung-la fought a grim battle. All the men were killed fighting.

A HANDFUL OF MEN

We must return to Tsangdhar where, by midday, some surviving troops were trying to get out in isolated groups, streaming out of the Rongla Nullah, past the overrun 1/9 GR positions on the Tsangdhar slope and then towards the